require continual contact with colleagues working on similar problems to keep their research from straying off in unproductive directions. But Einstein's intellect was different; he worked more fruitfully in isolation than in a stimulating milieu of other physicists.

Sometimes it helped him to talk with others—not because they offered him deep new insights or information, but rather because by explaining paradoxes and problems to others, he could clarify them in his own mind. Particularly helpful was Michele Angelo Besso, an Italian engineer who had been a classmate of Einstein's at ETH and now was working beside Einstein in the patent office. Of Besso, Einstein said, "I could not have found a better sounding board in the whole of Europe."



Einstein seated at his desk in the patent office in Bern, Switzerland, ca. 1905.
[courtesy the Albert Einstein Archives of the Hebrew University of Jerusalem.]